

diplomacy G8 SUMMIT

The summit waffles over climate change, the O5 is miffed at being seen as petitioners, the only silver lining: a pull-aside Manmohan-Bush chat that could break the nuclear deal deadlock

■ By Raj Chengappa in Berlin

The balmy weather and the warm sea make the Baltic resort of Heiligendamm a favourite haunt for Europeans out to rejuvenate themselves. At the entrance to one of the classical villas that adorn the coastline is an inscription in German that, when translated, reads: "Here happiness awaits you as you emerge healthy after bathing." Yet, the beauty and the healing powers of this quaint German seaside town appeared to have been lost on the world leaders who attended the G8 Summit. Long before the curtains went up on the three-day summit on June 6, protesters thronged the roads and parked themselves on the beaches with placards, and even at times without clothes. Rockstar Bono described the summit as "a lot of bur-aubabble". Security was so high that the German police threw a cordon sanitaire over the entire route from Berlin to Heiligendamm and the resort, controlling all access points. If any of the leaders got to take a healing swim in the sea, it must have been a state secret.

Manmohan Singh certainly didn't get to even dip his toes in the surf. The Indian prime minister and four other leaders from the so-called O5, or outreach countries—comprising China, India, Brazil, South Africa and Mexico—had been invited by the G8, the most powerful grouping of nations, to involve them in the big decisions and challenges facing the world. The economies of the G8 countries (the US, Britain, France, Japan, Russia, Germany, Italy and Canada) account for 60 per cent of the world's GDP but their population form only 20 per cent of the globe's share. In order not to appear too elitist, the G8 of late has been inviting to the summit the O5 countries whose combined population is about 40 per cent of the world's total.

Yet, as Manmohan pointed out to host Angela Merkel, the German chancellor, "We are only being asked ques-



tions and answers are being sought from us when we should really be involved in framing the questions as well." What irked the O5 leaders was that their meeting with the G8 was slotted the day after the summit was to get over, with a declaration outlining the G8's position on a host of global concerns. After conferring with leaders of the O5 countries in Berlin, Manmohan firmly told Merkel at Heiligendamm that if they were expected to attend the conference in the future, the meeting with the G8 would have to be scheduled much before the summit concluded. That, he emphasised, would enable the G8 to incorporate the viewpoint of the emerging nations in the declaration. "We have come here not as petitioners but partners in an equitable, just and fair management of the global comity of nations," Manmohan told Merkel.

While the G8 focused on a host of

issues—stability of financial markets, intellectual property rights, the Doha Round, non-proliferation, counter-terrorism and Africa's woes—climate change and possible measures to mitigate the resulting damage dominated the debate. Merkel had hoped to get the world's leading nations, including a recalcitrant US, the world's biggest emitter of Greenhouse Gases (GHG), to commit to far reaching targets to cap global emissions. Merkel wanted the leaders to agree on ensuring that average global temperatures do not rise by more than two degrees Celsius in the near future and calculate cuts based on such a target. It was estimated that developed nations would have to cut their emission levels by as much as 20 to 30 per cent in the decades ahead to enable that. The US balked at making any explicit commitment, and instead proposed a meeting of 15 of the world's